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ACADEMIC VAULT

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GST 101: Use of English I - Grammar, Concord and Comprehension

A practical companion for the compulsory Use of English course every UNIZIK fresher takes

GST / COMPULSORY

GST & Compulsory Courses

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Study smarter. Ask better questions. Pass with understanding.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Most freshers lose easy GST marks not because English is hard, but because they answer by ear. This pack turns the rules of concord, tense, punctuation and comprehension into short, testable patterns you can apply under exam pressure. It includes a sentence-error drill, a summary-writing method and a 7-day revision plan.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Apply subject-verb agreement rules to tricky sentences involving collective nouns, indefinite pronouns and correlative conjunctions.
- Identify and correct the ten sentence errors that recur most in Nigerian university English tests.
- Read a passage once and extract its main idea, tone and supporting details without re-reading everything.
- Write a clean summary and a short argumentative paragraph with a clear topic sentence and evidence.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

What the course is really testing

GST 101 is not a literature course and it is not a spelling bee. It tests whether you can use English as a precision instrument: can you say exactly what you mean, understand a dense passage, and spot a sentence that breaks a rule?

The paper usually mixes objective questions with short written tasks. Objective sections reward recognition - you either know the rule or you do not. Written sections reward structure. A candidate with average vocabulary and strong structure routinely beats a candidate with impressive vocabulary and no paragraph plan.

Treat the course as a small set of repeatable skills: agreement, tense consistency, pronoun reference, punctuation, register, comprehension and summary. Each one can be drilled separately.

- Agreement: the verb must match its real subject, not the nearest noun.

- Tense: reported speech and time markers must stay consistent within a sentence.
- Reference: every pronoun needs one clear noun it points to.
- Register: a formal letter and a WhatsApp message should not sound the same.

Concord: the marks hiding in plain sight

Concord questions are designed to trick your ear. Read for the subject first, ignore the phrase between the subject and the verb, then choose.

- Each, every, either, neither, everyone, somebody and nobody take a singular verb: 'Each of the students has a copy.'
- Two subjects joined by 'and' take a plural verb, unless they describe one idea: 'Bread and butter is my breakfast.'
- With 'either...or' and 'neither...nor', the verb agrees with the nearer subject: 'Neither the lecturer nor the students were ready.'
- Collective nouns take a singular verb when the group acts as one unit and a plural verb when members act separately: 'The committee has decided' versus 'The committee are divided.'
- Phrases beginning with 'a number of' take a plural verb; 'the number of' takes a singular verb.
- Uncountable nouns such as information, advice, furniture, luggage and equipment are singular: 'The information is correct.'

> **A 10-second exam habit**
> Cover the words between the subject and the verb with your finger. Read the skeleton sentence aloud in your head. If it sounds wrong with the short subject, it is wrong.

The sentence errors that cost the most marks

Examiners reuse a small family of errors because they separate students who understand grammar from students who memorise rules.

- Run-on sentences: two independent clauses joined by a comma. Fix with a full stop, semicolon or conjunction.
- Sentence fragments: a dependent clause standing alone. 'Because the lecture started late.' is not a sentence.
- Dangling modifiers: 'Having finished the assignment, the lecturer collected it.' The lecturer did not finish the assignment.
- Faulty parallelism: 'She likes reading, to swim and dancing.' Keep the list in one grammatical form.
- Pronoun ambiguity: 'Chidi told Emeka that his phone was missing.' Whose phone? Rewrite with a name.
- Double negatives: 'I did not see nobody.' Use one negative.

Comprehension without panic

Do not read the passage as if it were a novel. Read the questions first, then read for the answers.

1. Spend 45 seconds reading the questions and underlining the key word in each one.

2. Read the passage once at normal speed. Mark the paragraph that seems to contain each answer.
3. Answer in your own words where the question says 'in your own words'. Lifting the exact sentence usually earns nothing.
4. For inference questions, choose the option the passage supports, not the option that sounds generally true.
5. For tone questions, look at the writer's verbs and adjectives, not the topic alone.

> **Watch the qualifiers**
> Options containing always, never, all, only and must are usually wrong unless the passage says so directly. Options with some, often, may and tends to are safer when the passage is cautious.

Summary and short writing

A summary is not a shorter copy. It is a compressed statement of the main points in your own words, with no examples, repetition or personal opinion.

- Find the topic sentence of each paragraph. Those sentences usually carry the main points.
- Delete examples, statistics, dialogue and restatements.
- Combine related points instead of listing them mechanically.
- Keep the original order of ideas and the original tense.
- Check your word limit. Being far under the limit usually means you omitted a main point.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Choose the correct verb: 'Neither the Dean nor the lecturers ___ available.'

Answer: were. With neither...nor, the verb agrees with the nearer subject, 'lecturers'.

2. Rewrite correctly: 'Having submitted the form, the portal closed.'

Answer: The sentence has a dangling modifier. Rewrite as: 'After I submitted the form, the portal closed.'

3. Is 'The committee are arguing among themselves' correct?

Answer: Yes. The plural verb is acceptable when members of the committee are acting individually. Use 'is' when the committee acts as one body.

4. What is wrong with 'She gave me an advice'?

Answer: 'Advice' is uncountable. Say 'a piece of advice' or 'some advice'.

5. In a summary, should you include the examples in the passage?

Answer: No. Include the main points and omit examples, repetitions and minor details.

6. Identify the error: 'The number of applicants have increased.'

Answer: 'The number of' takes a singular verb. It should be 'has increased'.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write out the seven concord rules in your own words and invent one example for each.
- [ ] Do 20 sentence-correction items from any credible English workbook and mark every error by rule name.
- [ ] Read one Guardian or Punch editorial and write its main idea in two sentences.
- [ ] Summarise a 500-word passage in 90 words without copying whole sentences.
- [ ] Write one argumentative paragraph with a topic sentence, two supporting points and a conclusion.
- [ ] Ask a friend to mark your paragraph for agreement and punctuation only.
- [ ] Re-do every question you missed after 48 hours, not immediately.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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